

Session 2: Identity and its Intersections

The focus of this session is to explore the concepts of identity and intersectionality within the context of STEM. We will begin by mapping our privileged and marginalized identities, then watching a TED talk by Kimberlé Crenshaw and engaging with foundational readings on intersectionality. Through these materials, we aim to deepen our understanding of how identity impacts participation in STEM. Our synchronous session will provide an opportunity to reflect on our own identities, discuss how intersectionality influences personal and professional experiences, and analyze case studies that highlight intersectional challenges in mentoring relationships.

Things for facilitators to be prepared for:

This session will ask participants to reflect on identity, privilege, bias, and their own experiences. Facilitators should be prepared to manage the discussion thoughtfully and validate participants' experiences while keeping the session on schedule and running smoothly. Facilitators may find it helpful to reference the community guidelines prior to discussions.

Participant Pre-Work:

- **Objective:** Understand the concepts of identity and intersectionality and explore how these impact participation and representation in STEM.
 - **Activities:**
 - **Academic Wheel of Privilege:** Download the [AWOP](#) and circle the options that best describe your current circumstances in each category. We will reference the wheel during the live session.
 - **Video:** [TED Talk](#): "The Urgency of Intersectionality" by Kimberlé Crenshaw
 - **Article:** Read The Helpful Professor's "[15 Examples of Intersectionality](#)" by Dr. Chris Brew
 - **Submission:** Submit your AWOP through [this link](#).
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Synchronous Session:

- **Materials Needed:**
 - [AWOP Slides](#)
 - [Session 2 Survey](#)
 - [Survey results from previous sessions](#)
 - Access to Zoom and familiarity with creating break-out rooms.
- **Learning Objectives:**
 - **Objective 1:** Define and understand the concepts of identity and intersectionality.

- **Objective 2:** Explore how intersectionality shapes participation in STEM.
- **Objective 3:** Reflect on personal identities and biases.
- **Reviewing Survey Results:**
 - Before each session, all facilitators should plan to [review the survey results from the previous session](#). This is so they are able to incorporate any participant feedback into their session and make any adjustments.
- **Pework for Facilitator 2:**
 - Set all observers/facilitators as hosts (unless they want to be assigned to breakout rooms)
 - Set up first breakout rooms, random assignment of pairs, 13 minutes auto-recall (one minute to describe what to do, session has a one minute countdown after auto-recall)
 - Set up screen with 5 min google timer, ready to share
 - **Facilitator 2** starts recording, **Facilitator 3** backs up at starting/stopping recording for breakouts
- Note for all facilitators: make sure to rename yourself as “Facilitator” in the Zoom name.

Live Session Agenda:

- **Welcome and warm-up activity: 00:00 - 00:05 (5 min)**
 - **Activity type:** Group check-in
 - **Facilitator 3:** Start recording
 - **Facilitator 2** posts: “As you enter, type in the chat: Was there an identity in the AWOP that you were surprised by or noticed was invisible to you?”
 - **Facilitator 1** welcomes attendees and introduces the session:
 - *“The goal of this session is to provide an opportunity to reflect on our own identities, discuss how intersectionality influences personal and professional experiences, and analyze case studies that highlight intersectional challenges in mentoring relationships.”*
- **Slides: Identity and the Academic Wheel of Privilege: 00:05-00:10 (5 min)**
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 1** walks participants through [the slides about the AWOP](#) to prepare for the discussion. **Facilitator 1** notes Peggy McIntosh’s white privilege knapsack, explaining how having a default identity makes the experience of marginalized people within that axis invisible to them:
 - *“I like this activity because it reveals the many different ways our cultural identities impact our identities in academia. Often, we are not aware of our privileged identities, as described by Peggy MacIntosh in her 1990 essay on the Invisible Knapsack of white privilege”.*
- **Identity & STEM Participation: 00:10 - 00:25 (15 min)**
 - **Activity Type: Pair Breakouts: 00:10 - 00:18 (8 min)**

- **Facilitator 3:** Stop recording during breakouts, start recording after breakouts. If there are an odd number of participants, **Facilitator 3** will be in a pair.
- **Description:** Participants will pair off in breakout groups and discuss the following questions (**Facilitator 2** posts in chat before breakout rooms open):
 - How have your identities privileged your journey in STEM?
 - How have your identities hindered your journey in STEM?
- **Activity Type:** Group Share-Out **00:18 - 00:25 (7 min)**
 - **Facilitator 1** invites participants to share insights from their breakout sessions
- **BREAK: 00:25 - 00:30 (5 min)** **Facilitator 2** will share screen with timer countdown. **Facilitator 2** or **Facilitator 3** takes [attendance](#). **Facilitator 3:** Stop recording during break, start recording after break
- **Group Discussion: 00:30 - 00:55 (25 min)**
 - **Activity type:** Group discussion
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 1** reminds participants what intersectionality is – a framework that has been around for a long time (re: Sojourner Truth, Ain't I a Woman?) but was codified by Dr. Crenshaw to describe how an intersection of two marginalized identities is often rendered invisible.
 - *“As you saw from the AWOP activity, we all have multiple social identities. Our experiences are affected by our whole selves, which is the combination of these different identities which are weighted differently in different situations. Kimbrele Crenshaw gives us the example of a Black woman who wasn't hired because she was too Black to be in the secretarial pool, and too female to be a mechanic. This example emphasizes that we have to be aware of the interactions or the intersections of identities, particularly when we are in positions of power or mentorship. We have a few discussion questions, for which we'll have about five minutes each. We will read them out and put them in the chat as well.”*
 - **Facilitator 2** posts discussion prompts below in chat, one at a time, while **Facilitator 1** reads them out loud and facilitates the discussion:
 - What examples of intersectionality from the reading stood out to you and why?
 - Have you noticed any examples of intersecting marginalized identities in STEM, whether in yourself or others?
 - If you have a student who has two marginalized identities, how might you support them?
 - Have you ever been in a situation where marginalized parts of your identity conflicted or compounded your challenges?
- **BREAK: 00:55 - 01:00 (5 min)** **Facilitator 3:** Stop recording during break, start recording after break

- **Case Study/Application: 01:00 - 01:15 (15 min)**
 - **Activity type:** Pair breakouts
 - **Facilitator 2** sets up pair breakout groups (depending on the number of participants, approximately 8 pairs with two pairs for each case study (Case Study 1A, Case Study 1B, Case Study 2A, etc.). **Facilitator 3: Stop recording during breakout, start recording after breakout.** Participants work in breakout groups to analyze the case studies provided. Groups discuss how intersectionality impacts the situation by following the discussion points and sharing their proposed strategies for addressing the challenges present in each scenario.
 - **Facilitator 1** introduces the activity and reads out loud the guiding questions once they're posted.
 - *"We have prepared four mentoring case studies for you to example and discuss as pairs in breakout rooms. Each case study presents a mentoring challenge. We ask you how you would approach these challenges, considering the person's intersecting identities. The paired discussion will last for 15 minutes, at which point we'll come back and look for volunteers to share their analysis and thoughts with the large group. We'll post guiding questions in the chat as well".*
 - **Facilitator 2** posts guiding questions in the chat:
 - What identities/intersections do you notice?
 - How does the structure of academia exclude them based on their identities?
 - Implications for mentoring - how would you mentor this person? What resources are available for them? If you don't know, how would you find out?
 - **Facilitator 2** broadcasts a "3 minute warning" before groups close
 - **Share-out: 01:15 - 1:28 (13 min)**
 - Led by **Facilitator 1**, each group presents their case study and shares one key finding or approach.
 - **Wrap-up: 01:28 - 01:30 (2 min)**
 - **Activity type:** Pre-Work assignment
 - **Facilitator 2** projects the pre-work assignment slide ([final slide in the slide deck](#)) and shares the sign-up sheet in the chat with participants, who sign up on the spot for the article they want to read for Session 3. **Facilitator 2** posts the link to the [sign-up sheet](#) in the chat.
 - **Facilitator 1** lets participants know that the articles are in the folder for week 3.
 - **Facilitator 3** shares the link to the [Session 2 Survey](#) in the chat and asks participants to complete it as soon as they can.
 - **Facilitator 1** thanks participants for joining and ends the session.
 - **Facilitator 3** stops the recording.
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Facilitator Notes:

The Facilitators should spend time writing down everything they observed during the session (what worked, what didn't, and what improvements need to be made). They can also include advice for the next facilitator to watch out for. Facilitators may use the following guiding questions:

- How did the session go?
- Was there active participation in discussions?
- Do you feel like the learning objectives were met?
- Are there topics that need to be revisited in the next session?
- Were participants fully engaged when discussing their own mentoring experiences or goals?
- Were there times of vulnerability, disagreement, or hesitation? How were they managed?
- Did the conversation about group norms seem genuine and open? Were any important issues addressed?
- Are there any organizational improvements (tech, timing, breakout structure) to be addressed before the next session?